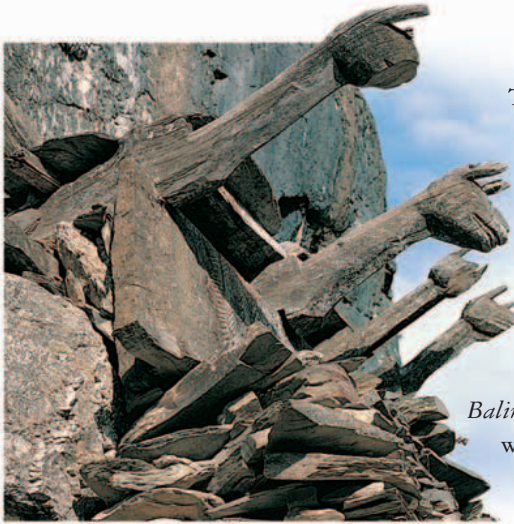




they do not look like other Pakistani people. Unlike most of Pakistan's population, they are not Muslims, but follow their own nature-based religion which bears some similarities to the ancient Greek religion.

The Kalash are not permitted to worship their main god directly but only via lesser gods. They believe in demons and witches—who must be avoided—and in fairies, who inhabit certain mountains.



SACRIFICIAL ALTAR

The most important Kalash festival is *Chaumos*, which lasts for two weeks around the time of the winter solstice. On the final day of *Chaumos* large numbers of male goats are ritually slaughtered in front of an altar dedicated to the god *Balimain*. The altar is decorated with four horse heads carved in wood because the god is said to appear on a horse.

OPEN GRAVE



When someone dies people sing, dance, and mourn for two days and nights before the burial. Until 30 years ago the Kalash did not bury their dead at all but left them in open wooden coffins. They stopped doing this because the graves were raided by dogs.

Unlike elsewhere in Pakistan, Kalash women do not wear veils or cover their hair.



WOMEN'S CLOTHING

A plain black dress, called a *piran*, provides the basis of the clothing worn by Kalash women. It is decorated with an embroidered sash and elaborate embroidery on the chest and cuffs. Strands of colored beads and a headdress complete the outfit. On special occasions a different headdress is worn which features an enormous pom-pom on the top.



Headdresses are studded with buttons and cowrie shells.

CROWNING GLORY

Kalash women wear their hair divided into five braided strands, with the middle strand emerging from the front of the head. Over this sits a headband thickly decorated with shells and beads running down the back of the head to the waist. They comb their hair outside near a river because they believe it brings bad luck to do this indoors.

